

areas, instead of ruling them out completely. He also advocated for Government-constructed and Government-run railways. His successor, Lord Mayo (1869–72), reiterated the economic viability of narrower gauge lines until finally the administration agreed, and in early 1871 fixed it at 3 ft 3 $\frac{3}{8}$ in.

Breaking the gauge

The debate did not end here and even found its way to Britain and the House of Commons. Assurances had to be given to the Members of Parliament that the introduction of different gauges would be carefully considered.

This happened as the construction on the highly strategic frontier lines of the Indus Valley and Lahore to Peshawar (in present-day Pakistan) began, using the metre gauge. Following a huge hue and cry in England, the secretary of state had to reconsider using the metre gauge for places of military importance. After four years of debate, the frontier lines were built using the standard broad gauge (5 ft 6 in) rails.

The Government's plan now was to use two gauges. The trunk lines would be broad gauge to serve key stations, which were of economic and military or strategic importance. They alone would have access to the ports. The narrower metre gauge would be used as secondary lines for areas that were not profitable.

The rise of the metre gauge

Between the late 1800s and early 1900s, metre-gauge lines had started making a real impact. They expanded from the north and east of the River Ganges into the states of Rajasthan and Gujarat (the Rajputana–Malwa line was on a metre gauge) and also towards the south and west of Bombay and Madras. Canadian historian Ian J Kerr noted that some metre-gauge lines were no longer “subservient” to the broad gauge, but had become “competitors”.

Metre-gauge lines had become more efficient with improved rolling stock and soon connected other lines, giving them access to the economic hubs previously reserved for the broad gauge. “The prospect of two competing national rail networks operating on different gauges